

6.3 The Sinhalese

The Sinhalese are the descendants of the ancient Aryans who migrated from North India to Sri Lanka in the sixth or fifth century B.C.³ Though the Sinhalese were enumerated as one ethnic group at the earlier censuses, they have been differentiated into Low Country Sinhalese and Kandyan Sinhalese since the Census of 1901

The total Sinhalese population has grown from 1.8 million in 1881 to 9.1 million in 1971. Their proportion to the total population has also increased from 66.9 percent in 1881 to 72 percent in 1971. Since they are an indigenous group, native to Sri Lanka only, the growth of the Sinhalese was solely due to natural increase.

TABLE 6.3 : ANNUAL AVERAGE GROWTH RATES (PERCENTAGES) OF ETHNIC GROUPS DURING INTERCENSAL PERIODS

	1881- 1891	1891- 1901	1901- 1911	1911- 1921	1921- 1946	1946- 1953	1953- 1963	1963- 1971
All Races	0.9	1.7	1.4	0.9	1.6	2.8	2.7	2.2
Sinhalese	1.0	1.4	1.5	1.0	1.7	2.8	2.9	2.4
Low Country Sinhalese			1.6	1.2	1.6	2.6	2.5	2.3
Kandyan Sinhalese			1.4	0.9	1.8	3.2	3.2	2.4
Tamils	0.6	2.8	1.0	0.6	1.2	3.0	2.5	1.0
Ceylon Tamils				0.3	1.4	2.7	2.7	2.5
Indian Tamils				1.3	1.0	3.2	2.3	1.8
Moors	0.7	1.4	1.6	0.7	1.4	3.2	2.8	2.8
Ceylon Moors				0.7	1.6	3.1	3.0	3.5
Indian Moors				0.1	0.3	4.2	1.5	-8.6
Burghers & Europeans	1.7	1.0	1.3	0.9	1.4	1.4	-	-0.2
Malays	1.3	1.6	0.9	0.3	2.1	1.8	2.5	3.2

Table 6.3 gives the annual average rates of growth of each ethnic group during the intercensal periods since 1881. The intercensal growth rate of the total Sinhalese population has exceeded 2 percent per year since 1946, the highest growth rate experienced by the Sinhalese being 2.9 percent during 1953-63. The rate of 2.4 percent during 1963-71 is lower than that of the Ceylon Moors and Ceylon Tamil during the same period.

The Low Country Sinhalese - The Sinhalese who traced their origin to the districts in the Western and Southern parts of the Island, i.e. Puttalam, Colombo, Kalutara, Galle, Matara and Hambantota, were generally classified as the Low Country Sinhalese. Though they comprised the majority, their proportionate share of the total Sinhalese population had declined from 63.9 percent in 1921 to 61.8 percent in 1953 and then to 59.4 percent in 1971.

The rate of growth of the Low Country Sinhalese was higher than that of the Kandyan Sinhalese upto 1921 but has been lower thereafter. According to Table 6.3 the intercensal rate of growth of the Low Country Sinhalese has been less than 2 percent per year prior to 1921-1946. After 1946, this rate had been increasing rapidly and reached 2.5 percent per annum in 1953-1963 and in 1963-1971 it had declined to

3 History of Ceylon, University of Ceylon Press Board, Vol.I, Part 1, Page 83